alms on which they live' and many even 'have estates while others live in the houses of worship, as in monasteries, which possess good revenues. Some are great eaters and never work except to feed well'.

A third kind of elite men, writes Barbosa, dangle 'a stone the size of an egg' around their necks, eat no meat and are merchants and traders. They take only one wife but when the man dies, 'the wife buries herself alive' while standing in a 'hole deep enough' as others shovel in the earth around her. Two decades later, Nuniz mentioned this custom too but ascribed it only to one particular Telugu group. Barbosa marvels at the power of ideas like honour and reputation that 'induce these women to submit of their own will to such a horrible end'.

The social customs Barbosa describes were those of upper-caste elites—a small minority that dominated his milieu. It's not clear if he ever interacted with people of the lower classes in Vijayanagar, many of whom must have lived in the thatched homes he noticed in the city. He superficially equated Hindu society's divisions to European ones, i.e., nobility, priests and merchants, rather than exploring the far more complex divisions of caste and untouchability common in Vijayanagar. But that's hardly surprising; like most outsiders, he too was unable to penetrate many intricacies of Indian social life. He had spent most of his fifteen years in India in coastal Kerala working as a translator and clerk with local kings.

In 1519, Barbosa joined his brother-in-law, Ferdinand Magellan, on the first circumnavigation of the earth, but died in the Philippines before he could complete it.

Domingo Paes

When Domingo Paes visited in 1520, Krishnadevaraya was halfway into his reign. In his account, Paes calls him 'the most feared and perfect king', 'a man of much justice but given to fits of rage', who 'seeks to honor foreigners'.[16] He 'has twelve lawful wives, of whom there are three principal ones', each in her own house with other maidens and female guards who can 'handle sword and shield' and wrestle. These women 'are never seen by any [unapproved] man . . . When they wish to go out they are carried in litters shut up and closed', accompanied by hundreds of eunuchs.